has always been a precondition that kept India together. According to Sahgal, the British had more political space to manuevre the coalition approach towards Afghanistan after 2009, and it was London's 'understanding that they can't have an antagonistic Pakistan till the time they pull out'.[95] This was not it, even top MI and R&AW officials viewed British involvement in Afghanistan with suspicion.[96] Most Indian policymakers interviewed for this book attributed British advocacy of reconciliation as (1) a colonial bias in favour of Pakistan, and (2) a quid pro quo with Pakistan, whose help was needed by the UK government to keep a check on radicalisation of the one million plus Pakistani diaspora in the UK (especially the Mirpuri community from Pakistan-administered Kashmir).

Two FCO officials working on Afghanistan and South Asia counter that India misunderstood London's political intent in Afghanistan and the situation on ground. 'The US-Afghanistan SPA had sent out the signal that the West is not going anywhere. That US, UK, and their allies will not cut funding and that the situation will not be as bad as it was after Soviet financial support to Najibullah dried out in 1990s,' they say.[97] The strong Indian perception of Afghanistan slipping into civil war after 2014, they worried, might lead New Delhi to reignite its military links with former UF delegates leading to 'sure shot confrontation' with Pakistan.[98] Underlining this point was H, a senior Western official posted in Kabul until 2009. 'There was a sense in India that the UK is more sympathetic to Pakistan. The London conference was perceived wrongly. That conference was inevitable as the decision was taken way before. India's non-accommodation or lack of acceptance of the idea of reconciliation was more of an embarrassment to its leadership than any sort of diplomatic disaster for India or diplomatic victory for Pakistan. The accusation was that reconciliation was not possible. I think that there was slow-footedness from India's side to adapt' he says.[99] Bifurcating India's Afghanistan diplomacy into two angles which were official and unofficial, H argued that in his unofficial interactions with Indian diplomats he could tell that there were people who supported the idea of taking sides and supporting factions (partisans) in case the security situation deteriorated, or even otherwise.[100]

Such partisan advocacy, however, H concurred, was different from the formal conciliatory policy line. Recognising a shift in India's staunch anti-Taliban policy stance in 2010, H mentioned that some Indian officials understood the rationale